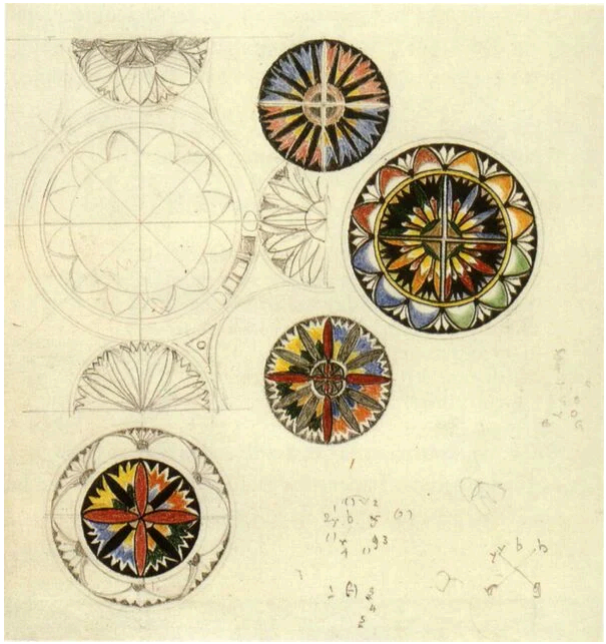
Heraldry

Visual symbols and their meanings

Heraldic devices, **emblems** and **flags** are a minor element throughout of the legendarium.

In the first phase of his mythology in *The Book of Lost Tales*, J.R.R. Tolkien described the heraldic devices with vivid and figurative images, as can be seen particularly in the description of the twelve houses of the Gondothlim; but in later narratives, the devices became few and simple. However, around 1960-61, Tolkien also drew several devices for characters of the First Age, which are more complex, but also ornamental and abstract.[1]:191 This article deals with illustrations and textual descriptions in separated sections.



Sketches for Idril Celebrindal's heraldic device, by J.R.R. Tolkien

Drawings

After finishing his drawings in the 1960s, Tolkien defined some rules for Elvish heraldry:[1]:191

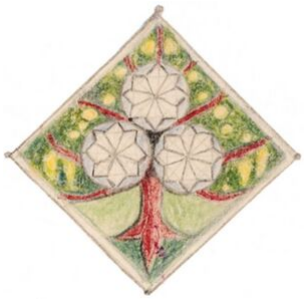
- Women's personal designs are set within a circle.
- Men's personal designs are set within a lozenge.
- General (impersonal) designs or emblems of a family are set within a square.
- The rank was usually held to be shown by number of points which reached the outer rim:
  - Four points were for princes.
  - Six to eight points for kings.
  - The great ancestors sometimes had as many as 16, as in the House of Finwë.

Elves

Since the personal emblems are set in a lozenge and house emblems are set in a square, it is likely that some of the Elvish designs below (for example, Fëanor and the House of Fëanor) could be used by a noble family, having them tipped forty-five degrees. Tolkien only made this variation with the emblem of the House of Finwë. Elvish designs are symmetrical on all sides, unlike those of Men, so they can be used in any position in a circular movement that may have reflected Elvish immortality.[1]:192, 194-5

Emblem	Holder	Commentary	Publication history
	House of Finwë	The original manuscript includes the note: "**Winged Sun / House of Finwe** [> Finrod] / **descending to High Kings / Fingolfin - Fingon / Turgon. Those / descended from Finarphin / used blue star**". Both of Finwë's devices depict a Winged Sun (in contrast with Thingol's Winged Moon); so Tolkien probably draw them with the later versions of "The Silmarillion" in mind, in which the Sun already existed during the Great March. In previous versions, Finwë dies before the Sun and Moon are created. The sixteen wings correspond to Finwë's highest royalty among the Noldor.[1]:192, 194-5	Tolkien Art Index #32 (https://tai.tolkienists.org/tai/32/).[note 1] • *The J.R.R. Tolkien Calendar 1974* (1973), back cover • *J.R.R. Tolkien: Artist and Illustrator* (1995), p. 194, #191 • *Pictures by J.R.R. Tolkien* (second edition, 2021), #47 • *The Silmarillion: Illustrated by J.R.R. Tolkien* (2022), pp. 36, 63
	Finwë	A lozenge variation of the previous device. According to the rules listed above, it would be Finwë's personal device.	Tolkien Art Index #63 (https://tai.tolkienists.org/tai/63/). • *The Silmarillion Calendar 1978*, April • *The Silmarillion Desk Calendar 1979*, May • *Pictures by J.R.R. Tolkien* (1979), #47

Emblem	Holder	Commentary	Publication history
			• *The Tolkien Diary 1992*, intro
	Fëanor	The original manuscript includes the tag "**Fëanor**". Along with Fingolfin's device, this one is clearly related to Finwë's, although its flames must be associated to Fëanor's name, "Spirit of Fire".[2] The coloured pieces that form the device could represent the creation of the Silmarils and crystals invented by Fëanor.[3]	Tolkien Art Index #33 (https://tai.tolkienists.org/tai/33/). • *The J.R.R. Tolkien Calendar 1974* (1973), back cover • *The Silmarillion Calendar 1978* (1977), February • *The Silmarillion* (1977), dust jacket (back) • *The Silmarillion Desk Calendar 1979* (1978), October • *Pictures by J.R.R. Tolkien* (1979), #47 • *The Tolkien Diary 1992* (1991), 1992-07-17 • *J.R.R. Tolkien: Life and Legend* (1992), p. 66 • *The Silmarillion: Illustrated by J.R.R. Tolkien*

Emblem	Holder	Commentary	Publication history
			(2022), pp. 53, 96
	House of Fëanor	Originally drawn by Tolkien, the art of the Doors of Durin was emended by a printer's artist before print. The emblem appears in the design of the Doors of Durin built by Narvi and Celebrimbor, who was the grandson of Fëanor. Gandalf mentions it as "the Star of the House of Fëanor".[4] In the 1966 *Index*, it is said that this star had eight rays and was of silver. It is probably a representation of a Silmaril, as the eight points are similar to the emblems of Fëanor (above) and of the Silmarils (below).[5]	Tolkien Art Index #20 (https://tai.tolkienists.org/tai/20/) • *The Lord of the Rings*, *The Fellowship of the Ring*, "A Journey in the Dark", Doors of Durin drawing, p. 305
	Silmarils	The original manuscript includes the note: "**Ancient / Emblem / representing / one derivation of / the Silmarils / from the light of / the trees upon / Ezellohar**". As noticed by Måns Björkman, this is the only device for an object, rather than a person. It could have been used by the Noldor in the War of the Jewels as a mark of intentions against Morgoth.[3] The depicted tree is Laurelin, with its characteristic green and golden colours.	Tolkien Art Index #67 (https://tai.tolkienists.org/tai/67/). • *The Silmarillion Calendar 1978* (1977), April • *Pictures by J.R.R. Tolkien* (1979), #47 • *The Tolkien Diary 1992* (1991), 1992-04-04 • *The Silmarillion: Illustrated by*

Emblem	Holder	Commentary	Publication history
		This one, Beren's and Eärendil's devices are the only depictions of the Silmarils drawn by Tolkien.	*J.R.R. Tolkien* (2022), pp. i, 57
	Fingolfin; House of Fingolfin	The original manuscript includes the note: "**Fingolfin & / his house**". Its colours are similar to Finwë's, while its flames resemble Fëanor's.[1]:195 The stars upon blue field could be a reference to his shield: "*his shield he bore / with field of heaven's blue and star / of crystal shining pale afar*".[6]	Tolkien Art Index #31 (https://tai.tolkienists.org/tai/31/). • *The J.R.R. Tolkien Calendar 1974* (1973), back cover • *The Silmarillion Calendar 1978* (1977), February • *The Silmarillion* (1977), dust jacket (back) • *The Silmarillion Desk Calendar 1979* (1978), November • *Pictures by J.R.R. Tolkien* (1979), #47 • *The Tolkien Diary 1992* (1991), 1992-03-06 • *J.R.R. Tolkien: Life and Legend* (1992), p. 67 • *J.R.R. Tolkien: Artist and Illustrator* (1995), p. 195, #192

Emblem	Holder	Commentary	Publication history
			• *Tolkien: Maker of Middle-earth* (2018), p. 81, #39 • *The Silmarillion: Illustrated by J.R.R. Tolkien* (2022), pp. 141, 227
	Finarfin; House of Finarfin, Finrod	The original manuscript includes the note: "**Finarphin & / his House / esp. Finrod**". As Hammond and Scull explain, this device is more calm in comparison with the fiery devices of his brothers, appropiate for the one brother who stayed in the peace of Aman instead of joining the War of the Jewels.[1]:195 This device could be a stylized version of the crown of golden flowers in his badge: "*For this ring was like two twin serpents, whose eyes were emeralds, and their heads met beneath a crown of golden flowers, that the one upheld and the other devoured; that was the badge of Finarfin and his house*".[7]	Tolkien Art Index #310 (https://tai.tolkienists.org/tai/310/) • *J.R.R. Tolkien: Life and Legend* (1992), p. 66 • *J.R.R. Tolkien: Artist and Illustrator* (1995), p. 195, #192 • *The Silmarillion: Illustrated by J.R.R. Tolkien* (2022), p. 68
	Finarfin; House of Finarfin	The original manuscript includes the note: "~~**Finwe / ____**~~ / **Finarphin**". This emblem must be the "blue star" used by the descendants of	Tolkien Art Index #548 (https://tai.tolkienists.org/tai/548/). • *Tolkien: Maker of Middle-*

Emblem	Holder	Commentary	Publication history
		Finarphin mentioned in Finwë's device, but Tolkien seems to have opted for the one above and take this design for Eärendil. Notice that the design can only be used as a square, so according to the rules explained above, it must be the device for the House of Finarfin, rather than a personal one.	*earth* (2018), p. 238, #82 • *J.R.R. Tolkien: The Art of the Manuscript* (2022), p. 186
	Finrod Felagund	The original manuscript includes the note: "___ **emblem / of Finrod**". Unlike the other devices, Finrod's is not symmetrical at all, which suggests it could have been created by Men for him.[1]:192 The harp probably comes from the story of Finrod's encounter with the first Men that entered Beleriand, in which he played a harp for them (*The Silmarillion*, Chapter 17).[2] The flaming torch might be related to the wisdom Men associated him with.	Tolkien Art Index #64 (https://tai.tolkienists.org/tai/64/). • *The Silmarillion Calendar 1978* (1977), April • *The Silmarillion Desk Calendar 1979* (1978), August • *Pictures by J.R.R. Tolkien* (1979), #47 • *Tolkien: Maker of Middle-earth* (2018), p. 238, #82 • *J.R.R. Tolkien: The Art of the Manuscript* (2022), p. 186 • *The Silmarillion: Illustrated by J.R.R. Tolkien* (2022), p. 108

Emblem	Holder	Commentary	Publication history
	Elu Thingol	The original manuscript includes the note: "**Winged Moon / a black with stars / Elwë**". The motif of the Moon was clearly made in contrast with the device of the House of Finwë above, although the character is not related with the Moon in the stories. According to the Elves heraldry rules, Elwë has eight points, so he is half of the rank of Finwë.[1]:195-6 The relation with Finwë's device and its nocturnal motif probably shows that both started the Great Journey, but Elwë was left in Middle-earth's night by Melian's enchantment.[3]	Tolkien Art Index #38 (https://tai.tolkienists.org/tai/38/). • *The J.R.R. Tolkien Calendar 1974* (1973), back cover • *The Silmarillion Calendar 1978* (1977), April • *The Silmarillion* (1977), dusk jacket (back) • *The Silmarillion Desk Calendar 1979* (1978), May • *Pictures by J.R.R. Tolkien* (1979), #47 • *J.R.R. Tolkien: Artist and Illustrator* (1995), p. 194, #191 • *The Silmarillion: Illustrated by J.R.R. Tolkien* (2022), pp. 47, 122

Emblem	Holder	Commentary	Publication history
	Lúthien Tinúviel	The original manuscript includes the title in Tengwar: "**Lúthien / Tinúviel**". Lúthien is the only character with two different devices, probably due her dual nature: Maia and Elf. This one is closer to the device of her mother Melian (see below).[1]:196 The white flowers that appear in both of Lúthien's devices are probably associated with the niphredil flowers that sprang at her birth, as told in *The Silmarillion*, Chapter 10.[2] Although not related with Lúthien, the sun-like flower could be an elanor, as that plant gave both silver and silver flowers.[1]:196	Tolkien Art Index #30 (https://tai.tolkienists.org/tai/30/). • *The J.R.R. Tolkien Calendar 1974* (1973), back cover • *The Silmarillion Calendar 1978* (1977), April • *The Silmarillion Desk Calendar 1979* (1978), December • *Pictures by J.R.R. Tolkien* (1979), #47 • *The Tolkien Diary 1992* (1991), 1993-01-01 • *J.R.R. Tolkien: Life and Legend* (1992), pp. 77, 85 • *J.R.R. Tolkien: Artist and Illustrator* (1995), p. 197, #195 • *Tolkien: Maker of Middle-earth* (2018), p. 237, #81 • *Tolkien: Treasures* (2018), pp. 82-3

Emblem	Holder	Commentary	Publication history
			• *Tolkien: Voyage en Terre du Milieu* (2019), p. 270, #191 • *The Silmarillion: Illustrated by J.R.R. Tolkien* (2022), p. 81
	Lúthien Tinúviel	The original manuscript includes the title both in Tengwar and Latin characters: "**Lúthien Tinúviel**". See information above. This one, with white petals and stars upon a black background, is closer to the device of Lúthien's father Thingol as seen above.[1]:196	Tolkien Art Index #36 (https://tai.tolkienists.org/tai/36/). • *The J.R.R. Tolkien Calendar 1974* (1973), back cover • *The Silmarillion Calendar 1978* (1977), front cover • *The Silmarillion* (1977), dusk jacket (front) • *The Silmarillion Desk Calendar 1979* (1978), July • *Pictures by J.R.R. Tolkien* (1979), #47 • *J.R.R. Tolkien: Artist and Illustrator* (1995), p. 197, #195

Emblem	Holder	Commentary	Publication history
			• *Tolkien: Maker of Middle-earth* (2018), p. 237, #80 • *Tolkien: Treasures* (2018), p. 80 • *The Silmarillion: Illustrated by J.R.R. Tolkien* (2022), p. 21
	Idril Celebrindal	The original manuscript includes several notes: • In Tengwar in blue pencil: "**Menelluin Irildeo Ondolindello**" ("Cornflower of Idril from Gondolin"). • In Latin characters in pencil to the lower right, "**Idril's Device / The 'Cornflower' pattern / Menelluin. / Origin of (often / debased) Numenorean / circular patterns**". • In Latin characters below, "**Inlaid plaque / preserved from Gondolin / & descending from Earendil / to Númenor, whence it was / saved by Elendil & taken to / Gondor**". • Date: "**14/12/60**". This design can be seen as twelve blue flowers upon black field, or twelve petals upon blue field. According to the rules of Elven	Tolkien Art Index #37 (https://tai.tolkienists.org/tai/37/). • *The J.R.R. Tolkien Calendar 1974* (1973), back cover • *The Silmarillion Calendar 1978* (1977), April • *The Silmarillion* (1977), dust jacket (back) • *The Silmarillion Desk Calendar 1979* (1978), July • *Pictures by J.R.R. Tolkien* (1979), #47 • *J.R.R. Tolkien: Life and Legend* (1992), p. 77, #218; p. 91

Emblem	Holder	Commentary	Publication history
		heraldry, so many points reaching the outer rim signify her high rank as daughter of the king. Although the narratives give no explanation for this design with such colours, the blue cornflowers from the golden harvest could point to Idril's characteristic golden hair.[1]:192-3 Its design can be seen reflected in the Númenórean tile.[2]	• *J.R.R. Tolkien: Artist and Illustrator* (1995), p. 192, 189 • *Tolkien: Maker of Middle-earth* (2018), p. 237, #79 • *The Silmarillion: Illustrated by J.R.R. Tolkien* (2022), p. 116
	Idril Celebrindal	The original manuscript includes sketches and several variations for Idril's devices, four of them colored, but only this one can be considered finished. Tolkien seems to have opted for the one above.	Tolkien Art Index #119 (https://tai.tolkienists.org/tai/119/). • *The Silmarillion Desk Calendar 1979* (1978), October • *J.R.R. Tolkien: Life and Legend* (1992), p. 75 • *J.R.R. Tolkien: Artist and Illustrator* (1995), p. 192, #188
	Gil-galad	The manuscript (a postcard) includes this and below's emblem, both of them not being completely finished, but probably Tolkien would have chosen this, as its design is completely symmetrical, it is more finished	Tolkien Art Index #66 (https://tai.tolkienists.org/tai/66/). • *The Silmarillion Calendar 1978* (1977), April

Emblem	Holder	Commentary	Publication history
		and it ingludes **Gil-galad** written behind it.[1]:194 These designs are associated with Gil-galad's name, "Star of Radiance".[2] "The Fall of Gil-galad" mentions that "*the countless stars of heaven's field / were mirrored in his silver shield*",[8] which is likely describing Gil-galad's heraldry.[9]	• *The Silmarillion Desk Calendar 1979* (1978), April • *Pictures by J.R.R. Tolkien* (1979), #47 • *The Tolkien Diary 1992* (1991), 1992-04-24 • *J.R.R. Tolkien: Artist and Illustrator* (1995), p. 193, #190 • *The Silmarillion: Illustrated by J.R.R. Tolkien* (2022), p. 273
	Gil-galad	See commentary above.	Tolkien Art Index #309 (https://tai.tolkienists.org/tai/309/). • *J.R.R. Tolkien: Artist and Illustrator* (1995), p. 193, #190

Eärendil

Tolkien seems to have been quite invested with Eärendil's device, making more variations than any other. See Finarfin's second device above, which was clearly abandoned and used as the base for Eärendil's device instead. Hammond and Scull also describe a device for Eärendil with a star of six points, two of them being longer and touching the angles of above and below.[1]:194[note 2]

Emblem	Commentary	Publication history
	This drawing was crossed out and not emended. It includes elements from the two devices below, but it is unknown if it was done before.| style="font-size: 85%;"	Tolkien Art Index #35 (https://tai.tolkienists.org/tai/35/). • *The J.R.R. Tolkien Calendar* 1974, back cover • *The Silmarillion* (1977), dusk jacket (back) • *The Silmarillion Desk Calendar* 1979, February • *Pictures by J.R.R. Tolkien* (1979), #47 • *J.R.R. Tolkien: Life and Legend* (1992), p. 66 • *The Silmarillion: Illustrated by J.R.R. Tolkien* (2022), p. 235
	The original manuscript includes "**Earendil**" written in two different directions, so, as noted by the TAI editors, the orientation of this device is unclear. Considering Eärendil's story, the stars should have their tails travelling straight down, as if the stars were rising, rather than falling.	Tolkien Art Index #62 (https://tai.tolkienists.org/tai/62/). • *The Silmarillion Calendar* 1978, February • *The Silmarillion Desk Calendar*

Emblem	Commentary	Publication history
	Notice this device has only been included in two callendars, rather than a proper publication.	1979, February
	The original manuscript (actually an envelope, dated 13 December 1960) includes "**Earendel / Elrond?**". Being more detailed than the previous device, it was probably done later. The new incorporated elements were: a Silmaril, concentric circles (maybe remeniscent of the medieval celestial spheres), inner star points and the stars in the four points are changed by the phases of the Moon. The division into twelve points makes the device similar to Idril's, Eärendil's mother.[1]:194 The background colour makes the same connection. The phases of the Moon being different and thus breaking the Elven symmetry, could point to Eärendil's Half-elven condition.[3]	Tolkien Art Index #117 (https://tai.tolkienists.org/tai/117/). • *The Silmarillion Desk Calendar 1979* (1978), February • *J.R.R. Tolkien: Artist and Illustrator* (1995), p. 193, #190

Men

Men's designs are symmetrical, but unlike those of the Elves, only horizontally, with a pushing force upwards. This probably reflects Men's trascendental nature, unlike Elven's enclosed immortality.[1]:195

Emblem	Holder	Notes	Publication history
	Bëor	As Måns Björkman explains, following the narratives, this was the first device created for a Man, hence it is the closest to the Elven style, being symmetrical in each side. However, it is less refined and more grounded than the Elven designs.[3] | style="font-size: 85%;"	Tolkien Art Index #68 (https://tai.tolkienists.org/tai/68/). • *The Silmarillion Calendar* 1978 (1977), April • *The Silmarillion Desk Calendar* 1979 (1978), January • *Pictures by J.R.R. Tolkien* (1979), #47 • *The Silmarillion: Illustrated by J.R.R. Tolkien* (2022), pp. 131, 216
	Hador	The original manuscript includes the note: "**Hador**". Måns Björkman speculates that the fiery colours of this device could be related to those of Fingolfin's, as the House of Hador was a vassal of his.[3]	Tolkien Art Index #61 (https://tai.tolkienists.org/tai/61/). • *The Silmarillion Calendar* 1978 (1977), February • *Pictures by J.R.R. Tolkien* (1979), #47 • *The Silmarillion: Illustrated by J.R.R. Tolkien* (2022), p. 178

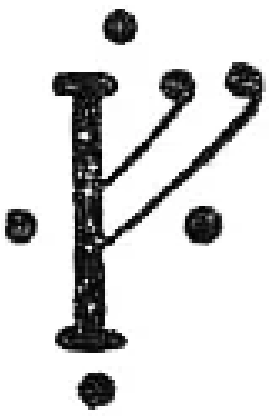
Emblem	Holder	Notes	Publication history
	House of Haleth	The original manuscript includes the note: "**House of Haleth**". Unlike the previous Mannish designs, several details can be identified within it: a tree, a vine entwined around it, leaves or fruits around its branches, and two white flowers beneath it. The grey background could indicate a dark forest. As Måns Björkman explains, its main characteristics may reflect the preference of the Haladin for forests and solitude. It is also notable that this device breaks the heraldic rules, as its lozenge form is not for a person.[3]	Tolkien Art Index #69 (https://tai.tolkienists.org/tai/69/). • *The Silmarillion Calendar 1978* (1977), April • *Pictures by J.R.R. Tolkien* (1979), #47 • *The Tolkien Diary 1992* (1991), 1992-05-08 • *The Silmarillion: Illustrated by J.R.R. Tolkien* (2022), p. 188
	Beren	The original manuscript includes the note: "**Beren Gamlost / historical / plaque**". Personal lozenge for Beren, created posthumously to commemorate his deeds. It depicts the three peaks of Thangorodrim, the Silmaril rescued from Morgoth's crown and Beren's severed hand.[1]:195 The star above could be a foretelling of the Silmaril's destiny.[3]	Tolkien Art Index #70 (https://tai.tolkienists.org/tai/70/). • *The Silmarillion Calendar 1978* (1977), April • *The Silmarillion Desk Calendar 1979* (1978), August • *Pictures by J.R.R. Tolkien* (1979), #47 • *The Tolkien Diary 1992* (1991), 1993-01-03 • *Tolkien: Maker of Middle-earth* (2018), p. 238, #82 • *J.R.R. Tolkien: The Art of the*

Emblem	Holder	Notes	Publication history
			Manuscript (2022), p. 186 • *The Silmarillion: Illustrated by J.R.R. Tolkien* (2022), p. 93
	Mannish holder	Nothing is known about this device, save it is of Man. It is reminiscent of Tolkien's Númenórean designs.	Tolkien Art Index #118 (https://tai.tolkienists.org/tai/118/). • *The Silmarillion Desk Calendar 1979* (1978), June

Dwarves

Emblem	Holder	Notes	Publication history
	House of Durin	Tolkien made several sketches for the Doors of Durin, which include variations for the emblems of Durin. With the last clean version, the art of the Doors of Durin was emended by a printer's artist. When seeing the Doors of Durin built by Narvi and Celebrimbor, Gimli points to them crying "*There are the emblems of Durin!*".[10] In the *1966 Index*, describes these emblems as "Seven stars (above a crown and anvil)". These eight-rayed stars represented the Plough.[5] The crown with seven stars are a reference to Durin's Crown as sung in the song *The world was young*: "*He stooped and looked in Mirrormere / And saw a crown of stars appear*".[11] The anvil and hammer is clearly a reference to Dwarves' skills. No other mention to Dwarven heraldry is given in drawings nor narrative.	Tolkien Art Index #20 (https://tai.tolkienists.org/tai/20/) • *The Lord of the Rings*, *The Fellowship of the Ring*, "A Journey in the Dark", Doors of Durin drawing, p. 305

Maiar

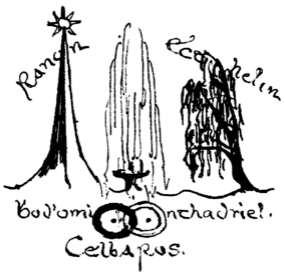
Emblem	Holder	Notes	History of publication
	Melian	The original manuscript includes the title "**Melian**". Hammond and Scull explain this is one of the most complex designs, probably reflecting Melian's nature as a Maia and how she reflected the light of the West like a mirror.[1]:196 However, it matches the design described in *The Silmarillion*, when Melian gave Beleg a store of lembas: "*wrapped in leaves of silver, and the threads that bound it were sealed at the knots with the seal of the Queen, a wafer of white wax shaped as a single flower of Telperion*".[12] When Túrin recognized the seal, he first refused the gift.[13]	Tolkien Art Index #65 (https://tai.tolkienists.org/tai/65/). • *The Silmarillion Calendar 1978* (1977), April • *The Silmarillion Desk Calendar 1979* (1978), September • *Pictures by J.R.R. Tolkien* (1979), #47 • *The Tolkien Diary 1992* (1991), 1992-08-14 • *J.R.R. Tolkien: Artist and Illustrator* (1995), p. 196, #193 • *The Silmarillion: Illustrated by J.R.R. Tolkien* (2022), p. 45
	Gandalf	Appropiate for vandalizing doors. "At Bilbo's front door the old man began to unload: there were great bundles of fireworks of all sorts and shapes, each labelled with a large red G and the elf-rune, ᚴ."[14]	

Emblem	Holder	Notes	History of publication
	Orcs of Mordor (Sauron's Orcs)	"The Orcs in the service of Barad-dûr use the sign of the Red Eye".[15] "a single banner, black but bearing on it in red the Evil Eye."[16]	
	Mordor Special Mission Flying Corps	The original manuscript includes the note: "**MSMFC / Mordor Special Mission Flying Corps Emblem**", as well as the eye and the name of Sauron. Probably a mere game by Tolkien, who probably saw that a flower resembled a pilot badge and decided to create one for the Nazgûl. The inscription "seen from below" indicates that it depicts a fell beast as seen from the ground.[1]:189-90 No doubt that if that is the case, it would be an extremely stylized portrait. Notice the Eye of Sauron included in the wings in patter.[3] This resembles Mordor's flies, which also had it painted on.	

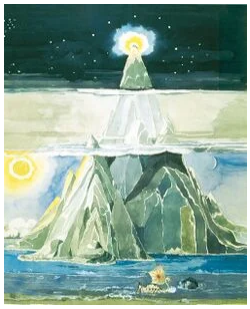
Early locations

In the early phase of the legendarium of *The Book of Lost Tales* (1916-20), Tolkien made three heraldic devices for towns from England (then the core of his mythology), which he laveled with the title "***i·glin grandin a·Dol Erethin Airi***" ("the fair towns of Holy Tol Eressëa"). As noted by the editors, these towns were special for Tolkien and his wife Edith in those years.[17]:93

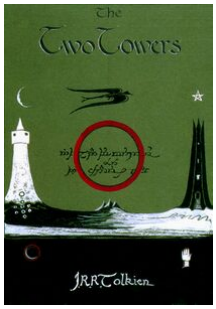
Emblem	Location	Notes
	Taurobel	Labelled "**Taurobel**" below, and "**Tram ·:· Nybol**" above. It depicts three trees, probably Lombardy poplars, above a three-arched bridge through which three streams flow, with some reeds on the banks. In *The Book of Lost Tales*, Tavrobel ("Wood-home") was a town with a bridge crossing across the confluence of two rivers. The label *Tram Nybol* ("?Snowy Bridge") seems to be the bridge's name, although the editors are unsure of its translation.[17]:94 Christopher Tolkien identified Tavrobel as Great Haywood in Staffordshire, where his parents lived soon after their marriage, while his father was still at service.[18] The bridge of both the devise and the narrative was clearly inspired by the Essex Bridge near Great Haywood.[19]
	Cortirion	Labelled "**Cortirion**" below, "**Tirin na Gilweth**" around the middle, and "~~**Miril i·durwin**~~" at the sides. It depicts a tall tower with a flag at its top, two trees at is sides (probably elms) and a shining sun at its left. Below, a peacock with a star in each side. In *The Book of Lost Tales*, Kortirion was the chief city of Tol Eressëa, and its name came from its tower (tall and grey), built by Ingil. Meril-i-Turinqi was the queen of the isle, who lived in a korin of elms.[20] As explained by the editors, *Tirin na Gilweth* refers to "Ingil's Tower", and *Miril i·durwin* is the Gnomish name of "Meril the Queen".[17]:95 The peacock is clearly reminiscent of the poem *Kortirion among the Trees*: "where even now the peacocks pace a stately drill, / majestic, sapphirine, and emerald".[21] Tolkien identified Kortirion with Warwick, where Edith lived from 1913 until their marriage in March 1916.[18]

Emblem	Location	Notes
	Celbaros	Labelled "**Celbaros**". It depicts a fountain with high waters. In its left, a mountain tall as a spike, with a sun at the top, and the tag "**Ranon**". At the fountain's right, a willow with the tag "**Ecthelin**". Below, two rings intertwined with the words "**bod'ominthadriel**". This is the only device absent in the narratives of Tolkien's mythology. Instead, it is closer to Tolkien's life: *Ranon* (maybe related to *Rân*, the Moon) and *Ecthelin* (probably meaning "Lady of the Fountain") are likely Elvish-rendered versions of Ronald and Edith's names. The two rings and the Gnomish term *bod'ominthadriel* (probably meaning "coming together, reunion") suggests the emblem is celebrating Tolkien and Edith's reunion and engagement in 1913, after three years of wait. Therefore, the editors identify Celbaros with Cheltenham , which is known as a spa-town with many fountains.[17]:96

Other related drawings by J.R.R. Tolkien



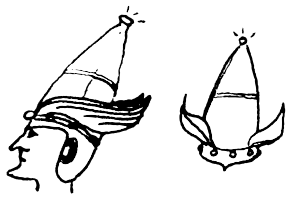
A solar emblem appearing in a Telerin boat in the Bay of Eldamar.



The Moon of Minas Morgul and Saruman's **White Hand** in the original cover of *The Two Towers*.



The **Livery of Elendil** in the original cover of *The Return of the King*.



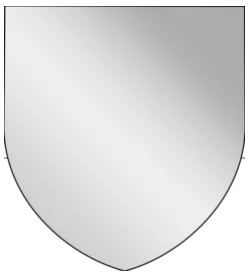
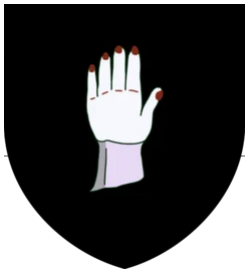
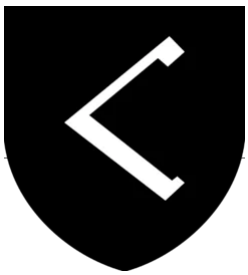
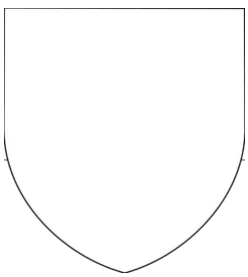
A detailed depiction of the **Crown of Gondor**, which appears in the Lively of Elendil.

In text

Apart from those he drew, Tolkien also mentions several designs throughtout the narratives, which are included here with a visual recreation. Notice that here the devices are depicted in a shield for consistency's sake, but in narrative, they are carried in banners, standards, seals, arms, stakes, etc.

The Lord of the Rings

Emblem	Holder	Notes
	Anárion; House of Anárion	**White Tree of Gondor** "*the royal banner had been sable , upon which was displayed a white tree in blossom beneath seven stars.*".[22]
	Aragorn; House of Telcontar	**Livery of the heirs of Elendil** "*There flowered a White Tree, and that was for Gondor; but Seven Stars were about it, and a high crown above it*"[23]
	House of Eorl / Rohirrim	The device of the **White Horse** upon Green field was used by the Kings of Rohan: "*the running horse, white upon green, that was the emblem of the House of Eorl*".[24] Thus, during the War of the Ring, Guthláf carried Théoden's banner: "*white horse upon a field of green*".[25][26][27] His heir Éomer will use it also in the times of peace thereafter.[28] However, this device was also used by the people of Rohan, as Éowyn gave Merry a shield of the Rohirrim "*and it bore on it the device of the white horse*".[29]
	House of Dol Amroth	During the War of the Ring, Imrahil, Prince of Dol Amroth came with his army "*with gilded banners bearing his token of the Ship and the Silver Swan*".[30] The Silver Swan could be seen during the following battles.[31][27] These symbols were later described as being combined "*silver upon blue, a ship swan-prowed faring on the sea*".[32] As Måns Björkman explains, the Swan-ships were built by the Elves to depart to the West, and the Elves of Lórien used Dol Amroth to do so.[3]

Emblem	Holder	Notes
	Elrond	Elrohir and Elladan headed Elrond's retinue to Aragorn's wedding with "*a banner of silver*".[33] As explained by Agnieszka Żurek,[34] this plain colour could be a reference to Vingilot (the ship of Elrond's father), which "with silver were her banners sewn".[35]
	Orcs of Isengard (Saruman's Orcs)	**White Hand**. "*Upon their shields they bore a strange device: a small white hand in the centre of a black field*".[36]
	Orcs of Isengard (Saruman's Orcs)	"*on the front of their iron helms was set an S-rune*".[36]
	Minas Morgul	"*a Moon disfigured with a ghastly face of death*'".[37]
	Haradrim	The **black serpent** was an emblem of a "*black serpent upon scarlet*" that was depicted on the standard of a chieftain of the Haradrim during the Battle of the Pelennor Fields.[38]
	Steward of Gondor	The stewards had a banner that was "*white without charge*".[22]
	Andúril	"*a device of seven stars set between the crescent Moon and the rayed Sun*".[39]

Unfinished Tales

Emblem	Holder	Notes
	Tuor	By command of Ulmo, king Turgon left in Vinyamar some arms for his future messenger. "*And Ulmo declared to Turgon of what kind of stature should the helm and mail and sword that he left behind*".[40] "*Now Tuor loved swans, which he knew on the grey pools of Mithrim; and the swan moreover had been the token of Annael and his foster-folk*". So when guided by good omens Tuor reached the abandoned realm, he found the arms and saw that the shield's "*field was blue, in the midst of which was wrought an emblem of a white swan's wing*". Recognizing the token as his own, the took the arms, claiming upon himself the doom they may carry.[41]
	House of Húrin	When Cirion sent several messengers to Eorl, they brought with them "*a small stone incised with the seal of the Stewards*",[42] which consisted of "*the letters* **R · ND · R** *surmounted by three stars, signifying arandur (king's servant), steward*".[43]
	Elendil	The Tomb of Elendil had engraved simply three letters: *lambë*, *ando*, *lambë*:[44] "*the letters were* **L · ND · L**): *Elendil's name without vowel-marks, which he used as a badge, and a device upon his seals*".[45]
	Isildur; House of Isildur	The **Star of Elendil** or ***Elendilmir*** was first a Númenórean gem, a "*white star of Elvish crystal upon a fillet of mithril*", that was taken by Isildur "*as the token of royalty in the North Kingdom*". With Isildur's death, the gem was lost and his son Valandil was given a replica, and this token was used by the kings of Arnor and the Chieftains down to Elessar.[46]

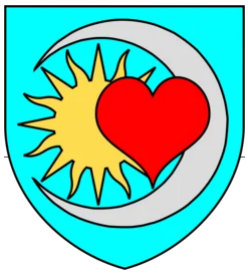
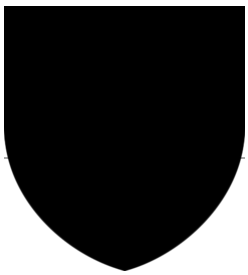
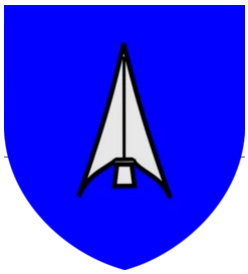
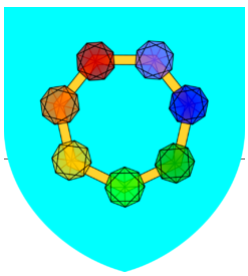
Twelve houses of the Gondothlim

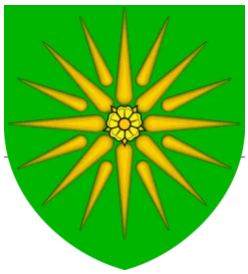
The array of the twelve houses of the Gondothlim in the earliest version of the legendarium in *The Book of Lost Tales* is quite detailed. Some of these folks have their emblems mentioned with

capitalized letters (the White Wing, the Stricken Anvil). However, from some of the houses no details about their heraldry is given, but like the others, most probably they had their devices based on their names and reflecting their raiments:

- The houses of the Pillar and of the Tower of Snow were both under the lordship of Penlod, so they probably had similar raiments.
- The house of the Tree had green raiment.
- The people of the Fountain were fond of silver and diamonds, and bore pale and bright swords.[47]:173

Below there are given the quotes describing the emblems hold by the other houses, keeping some pertinent mentions of their raiments.

Emblem	Holder	Notes
	House of the King	"*Mighty was the array of the house of the King and their colour were white and gold and red, and their emblems the moon and the sun and the scarlet heart*".[47]:172 Turgon had taken the scarlet heart as an emblem after rescuing the heart and defiled body of his father Nólemë during the Battle of Unnumbered Tears.[48]
	House of the Wing	"*[Tuor's] mail of silver gleamed; and about him was a press of the stoutest of the folk. Lo! all these wore wings as it were of swans or gulls upon their helms, and the emblem of the White Wing was upon their shields*".[47]:172
	House of the Mole	"*...sable was their harness, and they bore no sign or emblem, but their round caps of steel were covered with moleskin*". [47]:172 "*Now the sign of Meglin was a sable Mole*".[47]:165
	House of the Swallow	"*Now the folk of the Swallow bore a fan of feathers on their helms, and they were arrayed in white and dark blue and in purple and black and showed an arrowhead on their shields*". [47]:173
	House of the Heavenly Arch	"*But they of the Heavenly Arch being a folk of uncounted wealth were arrayed in a glory of colours, and their arms were set with jewels that flamed in light now under the sky. Every shield of that battalion was of the blue of the heavens and its boss a jewel build of seven gems, rubies and amethysts and sapphires, emeralds, chrysoprase, topaz, and amber, but an opal of great size was set in their helms. Egalmoth was their chieftain, and wore a blue mantle upon which the star were broidered in crystal...*".[47]:173

Emblem	Holder	Notes
	House of the Golden Flower	"*[They] bare a rayed sun upon their shield, and their chief Glorfindel bare a mantle so broidered in threads of gold that it was diapered with celandine as a field in spring...*".[47]:173
	Host of the Harp	"*They were dight with tassels of silver and tassels of gold, and s harp of silver shone in their blazonry upon a field of black; but Salgant bore one of gold*".[47]:173
	House of the Hammer of Wrath	"*The sign of this people was the Stricken Anvil, and a hammer that smiteth sparks about it was set on their shields, and red gold and black iron was their delight*".[47]:174

Gnomish banners

In some "Prose Fragments Following the Lost Tales", Tolkien wrote a short narrative about the coming of the Gnomes into the Great Lands (the later Return of the Noldor), in which their leader and their sons hold several banners:[49]



> "*Now the colours of the Gnomes were gold and white in those ancient days in memory of the Two Trees, but Gelmir's standard bore upon a silver field with a crown of gold, and each captain had a fair banner; and the sign of Golfin in those days was upon gold a silver sword, and of Delin a green beech leaf upon silver diapered with golder flowers, and of Lúthien a golden swallow that winged through an azure field as it were the sky set with silver stars...* "

The sons of Fëanor (here unrelated to the royal house) are said to be the ones who wrought the standard and banners, which shore either under the sun, moon, darkness or mist, thanks to their magical gems sewed in them.[49]

In the following versions of the story in both the *Sketch of the Mythology* (1926)[50] and the *Qenta Noldorinwa* (1930),[51] the banners are merely mentioned as being "blue and silver".

Portrayal in adaptations

Devices in *The Lord of the Rings* (film series) (2001-3)



Mural with Gil-galad's device in a banner. Art by Alan Lee.



Flag of Rohan in Edoras, seen by Éowyn.



Gondor's device in shields and banners during Aragorn's coronation.

External links

- Emblems and Heraldry (https://www.forodrim.org/gobennas/heraldry/heraldry.htm) by Måns Björkman
- Heraldry of Middle-earth on Wikipedia
- "The Eye and the Tree. The Semantics of Middle-earth Heraldry (https://www.academia.edu/4334565)", by Catalin Hriban. Published in *Hither Shore* 8 (2011), pp. 198–211.
- "Tolkien's Devices: The Heraldy of Middle-Earth (https://dc.swosu.edu/mythlore/vol32/iss1/7/)", by Jamie McGregor. Published in *Mythlore* 123 (2013), pp. 95–112.
- "Symbols of Immortality: A Comparison of European and Elvish Heraldry (https://dc.swosu.edu/mythlore/vol9/iss1/5/)", by Margaret R. Purdy. Published in *Mythlore* 31 (1982), pp. 19–22, 36.
- Tolkien's heraldry recreated (https://www.deviantart.com/aglargon/gallery/53078221/heraldry-in-tolkien) by Aglargon

Notes

1. *The Tolkien Art Index (https://tai.tolkienists.org/)* is a very detailed reference on the topic of this section. The notes from the original manuscripts that are quoted in this article can be found in each entry of the TAI. However the site has not been updated since 2018.
2. Unless Hammond and Scull were giving a wrong description of Finarfin's abandoned device, this emblem remains unpublished.

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3. Måns Björkman. "Emblems and Heraldry" (https://www.forodrim.org/gobennas/heraldry/heraldry.htm). Forodrim.org. Retrieved 15 May 2023
4. J.R.R. Tolkien, *The Lord of the Rings*, *The Fellowship of the Ring*, "A Journey in the Dark", p. 304
5. Wayne G. Hammond and Christina Scull (eds), *The Lord of the Rings: A Reader's Companion*, p. 280
6. J.R.R. Tolkien, Christopher Tolkien (ed.), *The Lays of Beleriand*, "III. The Lay of Leithian: Canto XII (Fingolfin and Morgoth; the meeting with Carcharoth)", p. 284, vv. 3539-41
7. J.R.R. Tolkien, Christopher Tolkien (ed.), *The Silmarillion*, "*Quenta Silmarillion*: Of Beren and Lúthien". Cf. also J.R.R. Tolkien, Christopher Tolkien (ed.), *The Lays of Beleriand*, "III. The Lay of Leithian: Canto IV (Beren before Thingol)", p. 191, vv. 1099-103
8. LR 1.11.083 J.R.R. Tolkien, *The Lord of the Rings*, "*The Fellowship of the Ring*", "A Knife in the Dark", Paragraph 83, p. 185
9. Wayne G. Hammond and Christina Scull (eds), *The Lord of the Rings: A Reader's Companion*, p. 170
10. LR 2.04.094 J.R.R. Tolkien, *The Lord of the Rings*, "*The Fellowship of the Ring*", "A Journey in the Dark", Paragraph 94, p. 304
11. LR 2.04.183 J.R.R. Tolkien, *The Lord of the Rings*, "*The Fellowship of the Ring*", "A Journey in the Dark", Paragraph 183, p. 316
12. J.R.R. Tolkien, Christopher Tolkien (ed.), *The Silmarillion*, "*Quenta Silmarillion*: Of Túrin Turambar"
13. J.R.R. Tolkien, Christopher Tolkien (ed.), *Unfinished Tales*, "Narn i Hîn Húrin (The Tale of the Children of Húrin)", "Appendix", p. 150
14. LR 1.01.026 J.R.R. Tolkien, *The Lord of the Rings*, "*The Fellowship of the Ring*", "A Long-expected Party", Paragraph 26
15. LR 3.01.034 J.R.R. Tolkien, *The Lord of the Rings*, "*The Two Towers*", "The Departure of Boromir", Paragraph 34, p. 416
16. LR 5.10.031 J.R.R. Tolkien, *The Lord of the Rings*, "*The Return of the King*", "The Black Gate Opens", Paragraph 31
17. J.R.R. Tolkien, "The Alphabet of Rúmil & Early Noldorin Fragments", in *Parma Eldalamberon* XIII (edited by Carl F. Hostetter, Christopher Gilson, Arden R. Smith, Patrick H. Wynne, and Bill Welden), "Heraldic Devices of Tol Erethrin"
18. J.R.R. Tolkien, Christopher Tolkien (ed.), *The Book of Lost Tales Part One*, "I. The Cottage of Lost Play": "Notes and Commentary", p. 25

19. J.R.R. Tolkien, Christopher Tolkien (ed.), *The Lost Road and Other Writings*, "Appendix: III. The Second 'Silmarillion' Map", p. 413
20. J.R.R. Tolkien, Christopher Tolkien (ed.), *The Book of Lost Tales Part One*, "I. The Cottage of Lost Play", pp. 16, 25
21. J.R.R. Tolkien, Christopher Tolkien (ed.), *The Book of Lost Tales Part One*, "I. The Cottage of Lost Play": "Notes and Commentary", pp. 33, 36
22. J.R.R. Tolkien, *The Lord of the Rings*, Appendix A, "The Númenorean Kings", "Gondor and the Heirs of Anárion", "The Stewards"
23. LR 5.06.062 J.R.R. Tolkien, *The Lord of the Rings*, "*The Return of the King*", "The Battle of the Pelennor Fields", Paragraph 62
24. LR 3.06.146 J.R.R. Tolkien, *The Lord of the Rings*, "*The Two Towers*", "The King of the Golden Hall", Paragraph 146, p. 522
25. LR 5.05.068 J.R.R. Tolkien, *The Lord of the Rings*, "*The Return of the King*", "The Ride of the Rohirrim", Paragraph 68, p. 838
26. J.R.R. Tolkien, *The Lord of the Rings*, *The Return of the King*, "The Battle of the Pelennor Fields", pp. 839, 847
27. LR 5.10.052 J.R.R. Tolkien, *The Lord of the Rings*, "*The Return of the King*", "The Black Gate Opens", Paragraph 52, p. 891
28. J.R.R. Tolkien, *The Lord of the Rings*, Appendix A, "The House of Eorl", "The Kings of the Mark", p. 1071
29. LR 5.03.092 J.R.R. Tolkien, *The Lord of the Rings*, "*The Return of the King*", "The Muster of Rohan", Paragraph 92, p. 802
30. LR 5.01.184 J.R.R. Tolkien, *The Lord of the Rings*, "*The Return of the King*", "Minas Tirith", Paragraph 184, p. 771
31. J.R.R. Tolkien, *The Lord of the Rings*, *The Return of the King*, "The Battle of the Pelennor Fields", p. 843
32. LR 6.04.044 J.R.R. Tolkien, *The Lord of the Rings*, "*The Return of the King*", "The Field of Cormallen", Paragraph 44, p. 953
33. LR 6.05.124 J.R.R. Tolkien, *The Lord of the Rings*, "*The Return of the King*", "The Steward and the King", Paragraph 124, p. 972
34. Agnieszka Żurek, "Heraldry in J.R.R. Tolkien's legendarium", in *The Coat of Arms: Annual of the Heraldry Society*, Number 239 (https://www.theheraldrysociety.com/wp-content/uploads/2023/10/Zurek-paper.pdf) (2022), p. 176
35. J.R.R. Tolkien, Christopher Tolkien (ed.), *The Treason of Isengard*, "V. Bilbo's Song at Rivendell: *Errantry* and *Eärendillinwë*", p. 103
36. LR 3.01.030 J.R.R. Tolkien, *The Lord of the Rings*, "*The Two Towers*", "The Departure of Boromir", Paragraph 30, p. 415
37. LR 6.01.030 J.R.R. Tolkien, *The Lord of the Rings*, "*The Return of the King*", "The Tower of Cirith Ungol", Paragraph 30
38. J.R.R. Tolkien, *The Lord of the Rings*, *The Return of the King*, "The Battle of the Pelennor Fields", pp. 839-40, 842
39. LR 2.03.049 J.R.R. Tolkien, *The Lord of the Rings*, "*The Fellowship of the Ring*", "The Ring goes South", Paragraph 49
40. J.R.R. Tolkien, Christopher Tolkien (ed.), *The Silmarillion*, "*Quenta Silmarillion*: Of the Noldor in Beleriand"
41. J.R.R. Tolkien, Christopher Tolkien (ed.), *Unfinished Tales*, "Of Tuor and his Coming to Gondolin", pp. 25, 27
42. J.R.R. Tolkien, Christopher Tolkien (ed.), *Unfinished Tales*, "Cirion and Eorl and the Friendship of Gondor and Rohan", "(ii) The Ride of Eorl", p. 297
43. J.R.R. Tolkien, Christopher Tolkien (ed.), *Unfinished Tales*, "Cirion and Eorl and the Friendship of Gondor and Rohan", "Notes", p. 313, note 25

44. J.R.R. Tolkien, Christopher Tolkien (ed.), *Unfinished Tales*, "Cirion and Eorl and the Friendship of Gondor and Rohan", "(iii) Cirion and Eorl", p. 304
45. J.R.R. Tolkien, Christopher Tolkien (ed.), *Unfinished Tales*, "Cirion and Eorl and the Friendship of Gondor and Rohan", "Notes", p. 316, note 40
46. J.R.R. Tolkien, Christopher Tolkien (ed.), *Unfinished Tales*, "The Disaster of the Gladden Fields", p. 277
47. J.R.R. Tolkien, Christopher Tolkien (ed.), *The Book of Lost Tales Part Two*, "III. The Fall of Gondolin"
48. J.R.R. Tolkien, Christopher Tolkien (ed.), *The Book of Lost Tales Part One*, "X. Gilfanon's Tale: The Travail of the Noldoli and the Coming of Mankind", p. 241
49. J.R.R. Tolkien, Christopher Tolkien (ed.), *The Shaping of Middle-earth*, "I. Prose Fragments Following the Lost Tales: (ii)", p. 7
50. J.R.R. Tolkien, Christopher Tolkien (ed.), *The Shaping of Middle-earth*, "II. The Earliest 'Silmarillion' (The 'Sketch of the Mythology')", §8, p. 22
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